ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

General IT English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For IT operations, service desk, infrastructure, cloud, endpoint, security, and platform teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.

- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.

- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.

- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.

- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

Alert
A notification triggered when a condition may require human attention.

Asset inventory
A current list of hardware, software, owners, versions, and risk-relevant details.

Audit log
A record of relevant system, user, or administrative actions.

Authentication
Verifying who a user, service, or device is.

Authorization
Determining what the verified identity is allowed to do.

Autoscaling
Automatically adding or removing capacity based on demand or policy.

Availability zone
A separated location inside a region, used for resilience planning.

Backup
A copy of data or system state kept for recovery after deletion, corruption, or failure.

Baseline
An approved standard configuration for a system or device type.

Change
A planned modification to a service, system, configuration, process, or environment.

Configuration drift
When systems gradually differ from the approved baseline.

Container
A packaged application unit with dependencies and runtime isolation.

CVE
A public identifier for a known cybersecurity vulnerability.

DHCP
A service that assigns IP addresses and network configuration to clients.

DNS
The system that resolves names such as app.example.com to network addresses.

DR
Disaster recovery: plans and systems for recovering after major disruption.

EDR
Endpoint detection and response tooling for monitoring and responding to endpoint threats.

Error budget
The acceptable amount of unreliability implied by an SLO over a period of time.

Exploit
A method or action that takes advantage of a vulnerability.

Failover
Moving traffic or service to a standby system when the primary fails.

Firewall
A control that allows, blocks, or inspects network traffic based on rules.

Gateway
The route a device uses to reach networks outside its local segment.

IaC
Infrastructure as code: infrastructure managed through versioned configuration files.

IAM
Identity and access management: systems and policies controlling who can access what.

IDS/IPS
Intrusion detection/prevention systems that detect or block suspicious network activity.

Incident
An unplanned interruption or reduction in service quality that needs restoration.

Latency
How long a request takes to complete.

Least privilege
Giving only the access required for the job, for only as long as needed.

Load balancer
A component that distributes traffic across multiple backends.

Log
A record of events or messages from an application, system, or device.

Maintenance window
An approved time period for work that may affect users or services.

MDM
Mobile device management for enforcing policies on laptops, phones, and tablets.

Metric
A numerical measurement tracked over time, such as latency or error rate.

MFA
Multifactor authentication: two or more proof factors for identity verification.

MTTR
Mean time to restore or repair; a common measure of operational recovery speed.

Patch
A software update that fixes a bug, vulnerability, or compatibility issue.

Phishing
A social-engineering attempt to trick a user into revealing information or taking action.

Problem
An underlying cause or recurring pattern behind one or more incidents.

RBAC
Role-based access control: permissions assigned by role rather than one by one.

Region
A cloud provider geographic area containing multiple data-center locations.

Replication
Maintaining copies of data or systems in another location or environment.

Restore
The process of recovering data or service from a backup or snapshot.

Retention
How long backups, logs, or records are kept before deletion.

Rollback
A planned return to the previous working state after a failed change.

RPO

Recovery point objective: the maximum acceptable data loss measured in time.

RTO

Recovery time objective: the maximum acceptable restoration time.

Runbook

A documented procedure for responding to known operational situations.

Saturation

How close a resource is to its limit, such as CPU, memory, disk, or connection pool.

Service account

A non-human identity used by applications, jobs, or integrations.

Service request

A standard user request, such as access, equipment, information, or a routine change.

SIEM

Security information and event management: collects and analyzes security-relevant events.

SLA

A formal service-level agreement, often with customer or contractual consequences.

SLO

A service-level objective used internally to set reliability targets and guide operations.

Snapshot

A point-in-time copy of a disk, volume, database, or system state.

SSO

Single sign-on: one identity session used across multiple applications.

Subnet

A range of IP addresses inside a larger network.

Tagging

Applying metadata labels to resources for ownership, cost, automation, or policy.

Throughput

How much work a system handles over a period of time.

Trace

A view of a request path across services and dependencies.

VLAN
A logical network segment used to separate traffic inside a physical network.

VM
Virtual machine: a software-defined server running on shared physical infrastructure.

VPN
A protected tunnel that allows remote users or sites to access private resources.

Vulnerability
A weakness that could be accidentally triggered or intentionally exploited.

Zero Trust
A security approach that avoids implicit trust and emphasizes verification and least privilege.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but ... .

Option A ..., whereas option B ... .

The comparison depends on ... .

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is ... .

The record shows ... .

Please confirm who has accepted ... .

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for ... . The correct information is ... .

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses ... .

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

A ticket says "the system is down." The requester can sign in but cannot export invoices. Other functions have not been checked.

Which action fails, and what message do you see? I understand that sign-in works but invoice export does not. When did the problem start, and who else is affected?

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Staff can reach an internal application on the office network but not through the VPN. Someone announces that DNS is the cause without testing it.

The problem appears when users connect through the VPN. DNS is one possible cause, but we have not confirmed it. Let's record the tests and distinguish findings from hypotheses.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

03 | Identity, Access, and Permissions

A temporary analyst requests administrator access to download a monthly report. A reporting role may provide the necessary access.

Could you confirm the report and actions you need? The reporting role may be sufficient. Please include the requested end date so the access owner can review the request.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

04 | Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Two cloud options cost $800 and $1,050 per month in a planning estimate. Only the second estimate includes backup storage.

The estimates do not yet cover the same items. The $1,050 option includes backup storage; the $800 option does not. Let's compare equivalent configurations before recommending one.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

05 | Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

A patch reached 180 of 200 managed laptops. Twelve were offline; eight reported installation errors. A manager asks if deployment is complete.

The patch is installed on 180 laptops. Twelve were offline and eight returned errors. Deployment is not complete; I'll separate those groups in the follow-up report.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

06 | Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

An analyst notices an unusual sign-in alert and sends it to the response team. The account owner has not yet confirmed the activity.

I'm handing over an unusual sign-in alert. The timestamp and alert details are attached; the account owner's confirmation is pending. Please acknowledge receipt and confirm who will coordinate the investigation.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

07 | Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

A change notice gave the wrong maintenance date. It said Tuesday, but the approved window is Thursday. Users have already received it.

Please disregard the Tuesday date in my earlier notice. The approved maintenance window is Thursday. I'm sorry for the confusion; the corrected notice below includes the exact time and time zone.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

08 | Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

A service dashboard shows normal server CPU usage, but users report slow checkout. A colleague says the dashboard proves the service is healthy.

CPU usage tells us about one part of the system. It does not measure the whole checkout experience. Let's compare it with request latency and errors for the affected period.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.